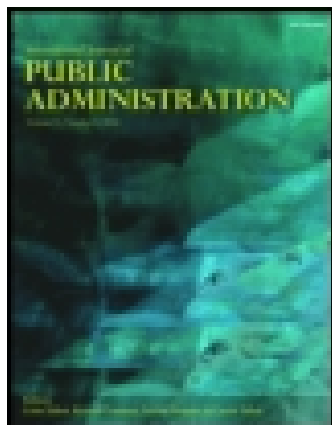


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Administration of the Persian achaemenid world-state empire: implications for modern public administration

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years of reign. He had one military setback in his expedition against the nomadic Scythians or barbarians of north-central Asia. Although he did not destroy them, they never again became a problem for the Empire. Darius built many palaces and actively engaged in massive public work projects, leaving behind remarkable legacies in governance and public administration, as he did in other areas such as economics, arts, and architecture.

Darius was succeeded by his son Xerxes, whose pomp and power as the Great King of Persia surpassed that of any other. Under Xerxes, the Empire did not expand—its Western expansion was checked by a setback he experienced in the war against Greeks, but his setback was balanced by his taking Athens and by making Greeks accept the King's Peace with conditions. Under Xerxes the construction of Persepolis was completed, and Persia reached its highest glory of organization, military force, and cultural and ceremonial extravaganza. The Persian Royal Court was the most elaborate; the number of foreign exiles, professionals, and mercenaries at the service of the King increased tremendously. Xerxes displayed the glorious power and status of Persia in the world while Darius was a great king, a great organizer and administrator, and a conquerer. But no king ever reached the status of Cyrus the Great.

ORGANIZATION AND ADMINISTRATIVE SYSTEM OF THE EMPIRE

The organization and administrative system of the Achaemenid Empire manifest unique features unknown before, with contributions to the modern administrative state. Although the Median administrative and court systems were adopted by Cyrus the Great, and some features of the Assyrian organizational structure were used in principle, the magnitude of the empire he had founded required a far more effective organization and administration. The vast Persian Empire was organized based on

a powerful central government, a strong *satrapy* system, a highly effective and efficient administrative system legged on a professionalized bureaucracy, a liberal governance policy, and a formidable army commanded by the great aristocratic nobility.

The Great King and the Central Government

A five-level hierarchical structure formed the refined systems of governance and administration of the empire, with an organizational authority flowing from the Great King and central government to the *satrapal* and local governments. This hierarchical structure may be divided into two general levels: central and *satrapal*. At the top of the pyramid was the Great King, his court, and the central government armed with an efficient, professional bureaucracy and the army; next was the *satrap* and his court establishment, followed by the sub-*satraps* in charge of the provincial and local administrative districts.

The state was headed by a hereditary monarchy. The king was the supreme sovereign, enjoying a religious sanction: "By the grace of Ahura-Mazda I am king; Ahura-Mazda gave me the kingdom" are the words of Darius in the Behistun inscription. So speak Xerxes and Artaxerxes in their inscriptions of Ahura-Mazda, the Persian God, "who made Xerxes (Artaxerxes) king."⁽²⁷⁾ As the Empire grew larger and incorporated the previous empires, the Persian kings "sought and obtained the sanction of the religion of these countries," nationalities, and peoples for their sovereignty.⁽²⁸⁾ Cyrus the Great was called to rule Babylonians by their god Marduk, and Darius and Xerxes adopted names relating to the Egyptian god Re.

The Persian King had supreme authority and recognized "no equal on earth."⁽²⁹⁾ His titles, Great King and King of Kings, had unique meanings to his kingship, for there were no other kings under the Persian King.⁽³⁰⁾ The Greeks called him *Basileus*, "the

one and only real king in the world."⁽³¹⁾ Cambyses was made king of Babylon—an exception—but only in subordination to Cyrus, who was the "king of lands." Like his successors, Darius claims that he is "one king of many, one lord of many; the great king, king of kings, king of the countries possessing all kinds of peoples, king of this great earth far and wide."⁽³²⁾ The succession from Cyrus the Great to Darius and all the following kings was based on the Achaemenid blood, and Darius's succession was based on the virtue of "his being the oldest surviving line of the hereditary royal family." Xerxes succeeded him because of his mother Atossa, the daughter of Cyrus.⁽³³⁾

The king's will as expressed in words was law. His word, however, was based on consultation with various sources, including the Persian nobles, the official experts of the bureaucracy (a custom required of the king), the Council of Advisors, the Council of Cabinet Ministers, and the regard for the countries and peoples of the *satrapies* concerned.⁽³⁴⁾ "The king of Persia might do whatsoever he desires," yet, in practice, he generally had regard to law and custom, and indeed "in certain respects, he was practically limited by the privileges enjoyed by the Persian nobles,"⁽³⁵⁾ including but not limited to the six prominent families associated with Darius in the overthrow of Gaumata the Magi. These families enjoyed unannounced access to the King, and only from these families could he take his wives.⁽³⁶⁾ Therefore, the King's supreme authority was limited by custom, tradition, and the nobility.

Second, after the Great King, the court played a formidable role in politics and administration of the Empire, for it was the central government. The centrality of the court is explained by the concentration of various powerful institutions, officials, and personalities. Clearly, the professional bureaucracy was the key institution of the central government (more on this later). Such key officials as the *arstibara* (spear-bearer), the *vacabara* (bow-bearer), *databara* (law-bearers or royal judges), *hazarapati* (commander in

Sardis, a major *satrapal* power center in the west and the end of the Royal Road.

The *satrapal* system in the united state of Persia was based on several organizational principles and institutions of political and legal control. These principles included (a) tolerant governance; (b) centralization combined with a sufficient degree of decentralization; (c) a multiplicity of institutional controls; (d) relative equality before the law; (e) the divine kingship—the Great King as the sovereign, supreme authority, and also the head of the State; (e) the standardization of the state functions and administrative processes, based on (f) a centralized, professionalized, and powerful bureaucracy.

Below the Great King and his central government was the *satrap*, the governor of an enormous territory with tremendous power in civil, judicial, and military administration. Appointed from Susa by the King, the *satraps* were almost always recruited from the Persian nobility, although initially this position was also assigned to exceptional non-Persians, and later to a woman. At the district level, great flexibility was exercised by the recruitment and appointment of non-Persian local leaders as well as Persian administrators and governors. Local peoples were also allowed to choose their own leaders. As will be seen below, the tolerant liberal policy of the system founded by Cyrus the Great allowed the diverse peoples and nations of the Empire to practice their local customs and traditions as long as they did not pose a challenge to the central authority of the sovereign and his protector of the realm, the *satrap*.⁽³⁸⁾

The *satrap* was granted a broad range of authorities, powers, functions, and responsibilities. His ruling establishment was modeled after the central government and the Great King's court. He ruled a vast territory covering different nations and peoples, even monarchies, and was surrounded by a miniature court of his own. He was the highest judicial authority and the head of the

state administration in the *satrapy*. His discretionary power was wide in policy and administrative affairs, but in major policy issues he had to defer decisions to Susa.⁽³⁹⁾

The functions and responsibilities of a *satrap* included maintenance of law and order; oversight of general administration; supervision in collection of taxes and tributes, as well as mobilization and supply of military forces and material resources for wars and defense; maintenance of the universal roads, and postal and communication routes; maintenance of the canals and other waterways such as Darius's Suez Canal in Egypt and Xerxes's Athos Canal in Europe, building and maintenance of public works; managing intergovernmental affairs with both the central government and other *satrapies*; and dealing with the neighboring *satrapies* on political and military affairs.

The fifth level in the hierarchy of the Persian governance and administrative system from the central government was the sub-*satrap* or provincial governor, an official recruited from both the ruling Persian or Median race and non-Persian local leaders. Thus, each *satrapy* was also divided into sub-*satrapies* or provinces headed by a sub-*satrap* or governor, totally responsible to the *satrap*, although provincial officials and peoples were not without direct access to the central government. The provincial or sub-*satrapies* were further divided into administrative districts headed by district administrators or political leaders of the local communities. For example, the *satrapy* of "Beyond the River" was divided into various provinces and local administrative districts, including Syria, Palestine, Phoenicia, Samaria, Judea, and Arabia.

There were of course strong *satrapies* and weak ones, but generally the *satraps* were powerful figures. And, in some *satrapies*, for example "Beyond the River," certain provinces were allowed some degree of local self-governance, such as the Phoenician city states which voluntarily joined the Empire and proved their continued loyalty to the united state of Persia.⁽⁴⁰⁾

Babylon lost its special status after a revolt that was put down under Xerxes, who then ordered its reduction into a part of the "Beyond the River" *satrapy*. That was the end of Babylon as a special *satrapy* or even as an important name.

Central Control of the *Satrapies*

Several institutional mechanisms established by the central government served as checks and balances in the *satrapy* system. This was essential for the administrative system to (a) maintain central control over the entire Empire; (b) forestall any possible independence, disaffection, and revolt; (c) prevent abuse of authority and power by the *satraps*; (d) prevent corruption and decay in the system; (e) protect the diverse subject peoples in the multinational united state of Persia; and (f) maintain the territorial integrity of the Empire.

First, there was a separation of civil from military administration in the *satrapy*. While in charge of civil administration with wide discretion, the *satraps* lacked the command of the military, which was given to an independent commander appointed by the central government and confirmed by the Great King. However, at times and based on personality, geographical, and kingship considerations, overlapping civil and military functions and authorities were also granted to certain *satraps*. Therefore, towards the end of the Empire, it is evident that some *satraps* assumed the both military and civil administration. The separation of military-civil administration denied the *satraps* the ability to amass both powers and to possibly challenge the central authority. The military commander kept the *satraps* under check and control of the central administration and of the king from afar. What was the chance of a conspiracy and joint revolt? Very slim.

Second, the independent commander-in-chief of the armed forces had enormous power, was close to the king, and was in control of the Persian army across the Empire. Given the rapid communication system in place, the commander was able to monitor any changes of situations in *satrapies*, and the central government was swift to respond to challenges or revolts in any part of the united state.

The third institutional control of the *satrapy* was the presence in the *satrapal* courts of the "eyes of the king," an official appointed by the king who performed as a state attorney in legal matters. Fourth was the inspector general of the state, the "ears of the king," appointed and removed by the central government. The latter institution was highly admired by monarchs of the ancient world and was adopted by Charlemagne, the first holy emperor of Rome, to secure "cohesion between the various parts of his empire" more than a thousand years later.⁽⁴¹⁾ The fifth institution of control was the periodic "examiners" of the state or representatives of the Great King who gave unexpected visits to *satraps* and their administrators and reported any corruptions and mismanagement in the *satrapies* to the central government.

The final institutional control over the *satrapal* position was the "King's secretary, an officer who forms part of every governor's [*satrap*] establishment" in the *satrapy*.⁽⁴²⁾ Appointed by and reporting to the central administration, this powerful official served as (a) an independent liaison between the king and his *satrap*, (b) a monitor to check the *satrapal* court and his administration, (c) the powerful agent of the bureaucracy and the king, and (d) a model bureaucrat for the *satrapal* and provincial administrations. He was the key officer-confidant who would read the king's letters and instructions to the *satrap*.

An example of how this official was instrumental to the effective central control over the *satrapal* power is the case of Oroetes, the powerful *satrap* of Phrygia, Lydia, and Ionia, who

had a thousand Persians as his bodyguards. To remove and punish him for many crimes he had committed and for his defiance of the central authority, Darius "called a meeting of the leading men in the country" for consultation to decide on the appropriate method of stopping him. Thirty of the company who were present competed so hotly for the privilege of undertaking this service that Darius was forced to make them draw lots. The winner at once carried the king's instructions and order to Oroetes's court, "opened the papers one by one, handing them to the king's secretary" with the instruction to read them aloud, ordering the guards to refuse to serve Oroetes. The instruction also included the words: "King Darius commands the Persians in Sardis to kill Oroetes," an order which was carried out at once.⁽⁴³⁾

Thus, powerful as the *satraps* were in their large territories, significant institutional mechanisms of control were exercised over them by the central administration of the united state of the Persian empire. Some of the above institutions of checks and balances were added to the system by Darius in his major administrative reforms discussed below.

Administrative Policy Toward Subject Peoples

A most important feature of the Persian system of governance and administration of the Empire was a universally applied liberal organizational policy of "tolerance and respect for subject peoples" throughout the far-extended territories of the realm. "The Persian was a tolerant government,"⁽⁴⁴⁾ with an administration characterized by both centralization and decentralization.⁽⁴⁵⁾ As a founder of the vast Empire with multinational peoples, Cyrus was very conscious of the settled civilizations, and he sought to create a united world-state with all diversities. He then adopted the liberal organizational policy of tolerant government. The traditional lives and customs of the many diverse peoples—indeed hundreds, even over a thousand—gathered into the vast empire were allowed to continue

at local and even provincial levels, as long as their local practices did not conflict with the centralized principles of administration and bureaucracy that were applied in carrying out the will of the king and in managing the political and economic policies of the realm. Administration of such a vast empire had to be flexible with respect to local governance.

Cyrus never abandoned—neither did his successors—the tolerant administrative policy towards the subject peoples, even when he had to deal with a subsequent revolt in Sardis, where he had appointed a Lydian in charge of the treasury. In Babylon, he at first tried a local leader as governor for three years, with his eldest son, Cambyses, as the viceroy and king's representative there, adopting the local conditions of governance and administration. Then Gobryas—the conquering army leader in Babylon—was appointed as the *satrap*. When Cyrus conquered Babylonia, a large number of Jews in captivity were freed and sent to Palestine in 538 B.C., where he ordered their temple be rebuilt at the expense of the royal treasury. He sent to Jerusalem "Sheshbazzar as governor with the store of gold and silver vessels that Nebuchadnezzar [the last Babylonian ruler] had removed."⁽⁴⁶⁾

The centralized system of administration was based on various governmental, political, military, and bureaucratic institutions as well as on some traditions. Centralization was the key to effective and efficient administration of the vast empire—effective for political control, and efficient for organizational and managerial performance. But decentralization also served the system in two ways: (1) it was a central component of the "tolerant governance" policy, allowing for local and provincial leadership and respect for traditions of the subject peoples; and (2) it provided the administrative system with maximum opportunity for flexibility and efficiency. Both organizational principles of centralization and decentralization complemented each other toward the effective administration of the empire.

chief of armed forces and the Immortals, the Ten Thousand permanent bodyguards of the King, or the Kingsmen), the Grand-Vizir or prime minister as the cabinet secretary, and *ganzabara* (the treasurer) as well as many VIPs were powerful forces in the court, accompanied by the harem later in the Empire.⁽³⁷⁾

Third, the strategic elite of the central government in Susa were the main governing power—after the King himself; the empire and its administrative system were based on it. Of this, the treasury as well as the legal and military elites constituted the most powerful administrators (more on the bureaucracy later). The above three powerful institutions formed the central government and the first levels of hierarchy in the *satrapal* administration of the Empire.

The Satrapy System

A *Satrapy* was an enormous territory, which included several nations, kingdoms, and peoples and was headed by a *Satrap* or governor appointed by the Great King from the capital city of Susa, the central government. Cyrus the Great adopted in principle the general organization of the Median and Assyrian empires, but the *satrapal* system of governance and administration that he established was a Persian innovation with distinct characteristics. The Assyrians and Medians had tried a similar system on a smaller scale, and had divided their territories based on vassal-kingship and provinces, territories that were much smaller than *satrapies* in size and importance. In contrast, the vast Achaemenid Empire was divided into major *satrapies*—20 under Cyrus, 22 under Darius, and 23 or more under Xerxes—which was maintained for most of the duration of the 230 years of the empire. For example, several *satrapies* included Egypt and Libya, Babylon, Syria and beyond the river, Asia Minor, Macedonia with several islands, India, Parthia, Media, and Bactria. The Greek islands were also grouped into three to four *satrapies*, including Lydia with the strategic city of

Unlike the Assyrians before and the Romans later who reduced subject peoples to slavery and obliterated their customs and traditions, the Persians, from Cyrus the Great on, maintained the universal policy of tolerant governance and administration. Not only were the Persians tolerant of the various traditions, customs, and religions in their realm; they took further steps and "actively supported the temple-worship of the gods of their subjects, or contributed to the building of their temples, and conferred on the priesthood and religious institutions special privileges. Cyrus and Darius not only permitted the rebuilding of the Jewish temples at Jerusalem, but laid the cost of it on the royal treasury."⁽⁴⁷⁾

The administration of the "Beyond the River" *satrapy* with Damascus as its capital was, for example, conditioned by two principles: (1) the "diversity of ethnic and national groups, exhibiting various patterns of relationship vis-à-vis the Persian authority, and (2) considerations of administrative efficiency, with allowance for the interests of the local groups."⁽⁴⁸⁾ "Beyond the River," with the territories of Syria and Palestine, was initially organized together with Babylonia as "Babylonia and Beyond the River," implying more significance of the former. It was soon separated, perhaps under Darius, into two *satrapies*, an organizational restructuring that was reversed, this time signifying the latter. Under Xerxes, Babylon was punished for the revolt and reduced to a province of the "Beyond the River" *satrapy*; its previous status was never recovered again.⁽⁴⁹⁾

Two types of organizational subdivision were adopted in the *satrapies*: (1) the administrative units for managerial efficiency and administrative purposes, and (2) the division based on ethnic, religious, and racial groupings in accordance with the tolerant governance policy. While the administrative subdivisions could expand or contract at different times, the ethnic grouping was generally unchanged. This dual system of administrative organization was one of the major innovations the Persians introduced to the governance system.⁽⁵⁰⁾ Both types of

administrative subdivision along with the organizational principles of centralization and decentralization were integrated in the professionalized bureaucracy of the empire.

The Persian Bureaucracy

After the king and the noble-led army, the bureaucracy was the most powerful institution of the Persian world-state Empire. It was the most efficient and most effective organizational instrument of governance and administration along with the Persian army. Its high efficiency was manifest in various managerial functions and processes, while its effectiveness was demonstrated in its performance as an instrument of political and administrative control throughout the far-extended empire.

The Persian bureaucracy was gigantic, centralized, and professionalized. Its size, functions, and performance surpassed any of the bureaucracies in ancient times. It was omnipresent and omnipotent in every corner of the realm. "Everywhere the armies of the Great King went, there the Achaemenid bureaucracy was planted with all of the comitants of administration—military, financial, and judicial—and communication with other provinces and [*satrapies*] was insured by the official language."⁽⁵¹⁾

The Environment of the Bureaucracy

The Persian bureaucracy operated in an environment that was both vast and diverse, stable and peaceful. The economy of the empire was prosperous, as the vastness and diversity of climate and natural resources of the empire provided an abundance of revenues for the treasury. The Achaemenid government recognized the significance of a sound economy for the maintenance and enhancement of the empire and its world-state scale of operations. Through various economic and financial reforms and with a sound

judicial system in place, the Persian economy throughout the realm developed with a monetary system, leading to the growth of early capitalism, mercantilism, and free trade.

Capitalism grew along with the feudal system of economy and social relations, where aristocracy maintained the ruling status, but the society was court-oriented and court-guided. Silver coins and other precious metals were used as major instruments of exchange; gold, which was plentiful, was used primarily for royal, political, and military purposes. Taxation was also based on kind goods and services, as well as on money and precious metals. An advanced weight measuring system was adopted, fixed and variable property taxes collected with efficiency. The diversity of the economic system in the extended territories from east to west, with all their climatic differences, provided the Empire with a sound and flexible economy. No doubt, the peasantry carried the burden of taxation, particularly toward the end of the Empire when overtaxation and bureaucratic abuse became major problems and contributing factors to its vulnerability to external challenges. But, overall, the economy flourished under the powerful and stable Persian Empire.⁽⁵²⁾

The prosperous economic environment throughout the Empire—with the exception of some areas and the drought years, of course—was conducive to the growth and development of professional middle class bureaucrats engaged in various activities of public administration. Rewards for government performance were available, and patronage appointments were numerous. Taxation was a major basis for revenue collection, but other ways of filling the treasury were unlimitedly available also.⁽⁵³⁾

Similarly, the political environment was highly favorable to the development and empowerment of the Persian bureaucracy. The Persian bureaucrat was in a dominant position vis-à-vis the subject peoples, but their power was not unchecked for fairness and administrative efficiency. Generally, the Empire enjoyed stability

Physical education was emphasized and would start at dawn almost every day, and children of the nobility went through an even more rigorous program of training. Cadet schools had been set up since Darius's time to train Persian boys for appointments to the army, the court offices, and administrative posts. Persians were also taught not to pollute rivers, to respect their elders, and to have mercy on the weak. "They have a profound reverence for rivers: they never pelt a river with urine or spittle, or even wash their hands in one, or allow anyone else to do so."⁽⁵⁶⁾ Persians were further taught to balance faults against the good deeds in judgment. As Herodotus reports,

I admire also the custom which forbids even the king himself to put a man to death for a single offence, and any Persian under similar circumstances to punish a servant by an irreparable injury. Their way is to balance faults against services, and then, if the faults are greater and more numerous, anger may take its course....What they are forbidden to do, they are forbidden also to mention.⁽⁵⁷⁾

One of the central cultural characteristics of all Persians was telling the truth and avoiding lies, for lying was considered a crime and subject to severe punishment, a key national cultural feature of Iranians throughout millennia to the present day. Other cultural features included a belief in "good thought, good talk, and good deed." Herodotus reports again: "They consider telling lies more disgraceful than anything else, and next to that, owing money. There are many reasons for their horror of debt, but the chief is their conviction that a man who owes money is bound also to tell lies."⁽⁵⁸⁾ While telling the truth was rewarded by society, the Persian judges and their justice administration were harsh on individuals who committed the crime of telling lies. These cultural values shaped the Persian administrative values and affected the bureaucratic behavior of the system.

The legal environment was similarly supportive, as the administrative-legal reforms of Darius (more on this later) provided

a universal legal environment in which equality before law was strictly observed. The Royal Judges and the process of jurisprudence would not have mercy on violators and abusers of the system.⁽⁵⁹⁾ In short, the Persian bureaucracy operated in a generally stable environment, where law and order were maintained well.

The Bureaucratic Elite

Persians were the ruling elite in both civil and military administration, although local elites were allowed to function as traditional leaders as long as they did not question the legitimacy of the sovereign King and the Persian authority. Persians, however, formed the formidable strategic elite in bureaucracy and public administration, as they did in the military. With few exceptions, only the Persians and Medes served as the major military commanders.

The strategic position of the bureaucratic elite was based on the economic privileges they possessed for belonging to the nobility. The nobility, therefore, provided the major cadre of the strategic bureaucratic elite in both civil and military administrations. This put pressures on the nobility for supplying the commanding manpower to the Empire. The operational bureaucratic elite were recruited from all peoples throughout the entire realm. The central administration, however, maintained effective control over the huge bureaucracy through both strategic and operational elites. Strategic management was a central feature of the Persian bureaucracy and administration across the Empire. So was emergency management, for the Persian bureaucracy was forced to be prepared for all kinds of natural and manmade emergencies. Nothing should stop the operation of the Persian administration. Persian bureaucracy was not without red tape, particularly concerning major policy questions that had to be addressed to the central administration in Susa and Persepolis. But

the greater overall efficiency of the administrative system often overshadowed any redtape that was expected in a gigantic bureaucracy.⁽⁶⁰⁾

Structure and Process of the Bureaucracy

The size of the Persian bureaucracy was gigantic, with an organizational domain beyond imagination. Expectedly, the local and regional bureaucracies had limited direct contact with their counterparts in other regions or areas of administration, for the eastern and western extremities of the Empire made it extremely difficult or impossible for such interorganizational communication. But such interorganizational communication was not uncommon among the bureaucracies of the neighboring *satrapies*. For example, the Babylonian bureaucrats had frequent communication with their counterparts in Media and "Beyond the River," or the bureaucrats of the latter *satrapy* with their counterparts in Egypt. Nevertheless, no local or regional bureaucracy could escape the control of the central administration.

The bureaucracy was divided into several great departments, each with a huge number of patronage and career appointees. The departments of treasury and finance, communication and transportation and roads, public works, justice administration, and internal law and order formed the most important organizational structure of the Persian bureaucracy. There were also a huge number of public or state enterprises managing various public authorities operating like private business. Taxes and tolls were collected at waterways, communication points, city entrances, roads, bridges, harbors, ports and forts, transportation facilities, etc. Public enterprises also managed production factories and service industries.

The royal court at both the central and *satrapal* centers were the largest of all bureaucratic establishments. Temples of all

religions also served as major institutional bases for the bureaucracy throughout the Empire. Although no clear statistical figure is reported by historians on the size of the Persian bureaucracy, a cursory estimation of the number of the personnel—patronage and career bureaucrats—performing a wide range of duties and functions indicate a bureaucracy of well over three million. This would include a range of functionaries from petty officers, informers, foot carriers, and workers in the courts to high officials in middle and strategic positions.

Persians never used slavery as a system of social and economic organization, but they benefited from an abundant number of mercenaries and contractual functionaries serving the bureaucracy, as well as from the conquered peoples obligated to provide various services to the united state of the Empire. Periodic services performed by subject peoples need also to be included in the overall size of the bureaucracy. Adding the above to the formal size of the bureaucracy, we may come up with a large figure of 6 to 8 million employees working in the Persian bureaucracy. Management of such a huge bureaucracy with a remote control was a gigantic task, particularly in the absence of the communication technologies available in modern times.

As mentioned earlier, the Persian bureaucracy combined a dual organizational principle of centralization and decentralization. While the central administration was in absolute command of the bureaucracy, the *satrapal* system provided adequate flexibility in the administration of provincial and district/local territories. The latter were allowed to exercise a great deal of decentralization while conforming to the overall centralized policies of the administrative system based in Susa and Persepolis.

The administrative functions and processes of personnel, finance, communication, organizational coordination, and justice were facilitated by various systems employing the most efficient methods and tools the ancient time could offer. Recruitment was

based on both patronage and merit, as the professionalized bureaucracy grew on a merit basis, whereas patronage and personally based recruitment were both common and considered important for political purposes. The treasury department was always the busiest organization in disbursing monetary compensations and rewards to those serving the state and the Great King.⁽⁶¹⁾

Professionalization of the Bureaucracy

Elevation of the bureaucracy and bureaucrats under the Median Empire had laid the foundation for professionalization of the Persian bureaucracy. The Medes were masters of statecraft, and they left behind an excellent administrative structure with exceptional organizational qualities. Further professionalization of the bureaucracy took place under the Achaemenid Empire with various principles which seemed to have remained significant throughout the duration of the Persians' rule. These included: (a) recruitment based on merit and knowledge, (b) prior experience, (c) long-term apprenticeship training, (d) adherence to certain professional rules set by the establishment, (e) constant eagerness and attempts to improve personal performance and achieve excellence, and (f) acceptance by the professional association or "guild system" which was highly protective and closed to nonbureaucrats. The bureaucrats as "men of pen" were highly regarded and enjoyed prestige, power, and privileges in society.

Professionalization of the bureaucracy also led to the formation of a strong civil service system based on examination, merit performance, and pay system. While patronage played a major role in the bureaucracy, professional civil servants thrived in the Persian administration. The professional civil servants provided the continuity of office and performance in the implementation of the official policies issued from the central and *satrapal* administrations.

While Persians as the ruling elite enjoyed a superior position in the Empire, followed by Medes, the privileges of a professional bureaucracy were by no means diminished for non-Persian bureaucrats around the vast Empire. Bureaucrats all over the realm were rewarded for good performance and for their professional qualifications regardless of their national, racial, or religious backgrounds. In fact, evidence clearly indicates that semi-slaves, mercenaries, and individuals of low social background were highly rewarded for their good service in the bureaucracy both at the central and *satrapal* administrations and were promoted to high positions. Jews, Greeks, Lydians, Egyptians, and other nationalities with slave-like backgrounds were able to rise to high positions in the Court bureaucracy, then to governorship positions of provinces and administrative districts. Nehemiah is one example, who served as an eunuch in the royal court, who through both performance and loyalty was elevated to high position in the central bureaucracy as "cup-bearer of the Great King Artaxerxes [440 B.C.] at Susa." Hearing bad news about his city Jerusalem, he "gained the ear of the King—and of the queen: harem rule prevailed in Persia. Leave was granted him to return and rebuild Jerusalem."⁽⁶²⁾ Ezra, "a priest and scribe," was also elevated and granted royal permission accompanied by a body of priestly, temple and lay followers, with rich gift for the temple, and extensive powers to inquire the religious conditions, to instruct people, and to appoint judges for all the Jews 'Beyond the River.'⁽⁶³⁾

The professionalized bureaucracy was central to the government of the vast territory, with vast diversity of culture, ethnicity, climatic conditions, and geographical extremities. It was heavily relied upon by the central government for continuity and stability of the united state; it was a uniting institution with a common official language and with a common goal of serving the state and the Great King. The Persian bureaucrat enjoyed power, prestige, and high esteem in society and in the government. While the professional bureaucracy provided the state with stability and continuity of functions, patronage played a formidable role for

political system-maintenance and enhancement of the Empire and its values. There were innumerable patronage officers who served the state and the king at level and each district.⁽⁶⁴⁾

There were both harmony and conflict between the career, professional bureaucrats who were held in high esteem and prestige in society, on the one hand, and the numerous patronage appointees who also held influential positions in government, on the other. The strategic political appointees were, obviously, entrusted in high authority and tasks of leadership. But their relationship with the professional bureaucrats was characterized by harmony, not hostility. It was not uncommon for the patronage appointees to lose in a conflict to the entrusted professional administrators who had proven their loyalty and competence to the State and the Great King.⁽⁶⁵⁾

Professionalization of the bureaucracy, however, led increasingly to such a high position in society that it was transformed gradually into a power contender, not vis-à-vis the Great King to whom it was loyal and subordinate, of course, but in general. As time passed, during the second century of the Empire, the excessive bureaucratization led to increasing possibilities for bureaucratism and abuse of power. This problem was compounded by overtaxation and resulted in a general public disaffection with the administration's bureaucracy. Eventually, it took its toll on the Empire, for the political and popular attitudes had already changed the perception of power among the peoples in the realm and made the Empire susceptible to the serious invading challengers like Alexander, who had never abandoned his idea of invading Persia but whose challenge Persians did not take seriously and did not make adequate preparation to meet his assault.⁽⁶⁶⁾

The administrative capital of the Empire was Susa, and the religious, ceremonial, or dynastic center was Persepolis, while Ecbatana (modern Hamadan), Babylon, and other major cities also served as commercial, strategic, and provincial capitals. Ecbatana

also served as a major treasury center, and hence an administrative capital. Pasargade was also an early capital of the government. Some of the major *satrapal* capitals included Memphis in Egypt, Sardis in Lydia, and Babylon in "Beyond the River." The official languages of the bureaucracy and administration of the Empire included Elamite, Akkadian or Aramaic, and the Old Persian of cuneiform script written on clay tablets. But Elamite and Aramaic continued to dominate the bureaucracy while the Old Persian served mainly royal purposes. The bureaucracy's effectiveness was also due to official languages of Elamite and Aramaic, which were used universally throughout the extended corners of the Empire. The twin languages served as a unifying communication force to connect all peoples of the multinational Empire.

Bureaucracy and Public Management

A central feature of the Persian Achaemenid bureaucracy was its ability to perform huge public management projects. These projects were of several kinds: capital project management, maintenance public management, operational management, organizational management, and development public management. Much can be learned from the Persian bureaucracy in the above areas, particularly in development management and capital management, the former for developing nations and the latter for the developed countries. The Persians relied heavily on team management, a system which was alive in Iran up to the 1960s, particularly in the rural/agricultural systems.

Team management has been a long historical tradition of Iranian public management, only to lose its application this century. The Persian bureaucracy managed massive projects of public works such as building and maintaining long roads to the far corners of the Empire, building and maintaining huge communication and transportation systems, building dams and underground irrigation systems stretching thousands of miles away from the water origin,

and the like. Strategic management was a key feature of the bureaucracy. The Persian administrative system became even more efficient since the reign of Darius the Great who launched major reforms in the economy, administration, justice, and management of the Empire.

The administrative reforms of Darius had several organizational and managerial themes that laid the foundation for a sound management system so necessary for the effective administration of a world-state empire. These organizational and managerial themes included: (a) the legitimacy of the Persian administrative state or bureaucracy; (b) the stability and favorability of the environment in which the bureaucracy and public management operated; (c) the sound leadership provided by the Persian administrative elite; (d) the professionalization and standardization of the bureaucracy; (e) the application of the Universal Law of Darius; (f) the liberal administrative policy of tolerant governance introduced by Cyrus the Great; (g) the antiwaste and anticorruption policies; (h) the expediency in organizational communication and managerial performance; and (i) strategic and emergency management.

The Administrative Reforms of Darius

The administrative reforms Darius launched were comprehensive, with far-reaching consequences. While Cyrus the Great founded the Empire, Darius reorganized and reformed it, with great interest in micro-management and details of its administration. During his reign, the Persian Empire reached its height, with a sound administrative system to maintain and manage its united world-state. The reforms of Darius focused on areas of governance in general and administration in particular. His governance policy did not depart from Cyrus's but simply reinforced it, whereas his organizational and administrative policies and programs extended far beyond what Cyrus had originally perceived.

Darius's administrative reforms covered the main areas of postal service and communication, taxation, economic management and financial administration, legal affairs and justice administration, and local government.

Roads and Communication

The communication system was highly developed to facilitate the dissemination of information necessary for the administration of the state and for keeping the central government informed of all events throughout the realm and to keep in constant touch with the *satrapies*. Various forms of formal and informal channels of communication constituted the core of the system for information dissemination. An efficient system of roads and postal services was founded under Cyrus the Great and was expanded under Darius, which linked all parts of the Empire to Susa and Persepolis. As Herodotus describes it, the road system was "excellently maintained and secured."⁽⁶⁷⁾ Roads were measured in *parasangs* (3.75 miles). All corners of the Empire were connected with major roads to the capital Susa and Persepolis.

The most famous of these roads was the royal highroad connecting Susa to Sardis in Europe, which, like other roads, had posting stations at regular intervals with well-maintained inns and caravanserais, and with garrisons at various stations. The other famous road was the road connecting Bactria, the capital of the northcentral region of central Asia, to Susa. These and all other roads also served the riding postal services, a pony express, which was a Persian innovation. Although the riding postal system was used primarily for royal and administrative purposes, commercial use was not uncommon. The riding messengers were ready on all stations, where by day and night and under any weather conditions they rode swift horses and delivered messages. While normal travelers took about 90 days to travel the Sardis-Susa road, the riding messengers passed it in five days. All couriers were salaried

wide range of other taxes and tributes. These included municipal and public enterprise taxes, tolls on major roads and waterways, taxes on harbors and marketplaces, animal taxes, property taxes, and the like. In addition to various taxes, tributes were fixed on conquered peoples, except Persians. Persians never paid fixed taxes, but they paid the heavy blood tax, as they provided the Empire with manpower for commanding military and administrative positions in the bureaucracy. The monetary policy of the state also affected the price and interest rate systems and, along with other financial measures, stabilized the flourishing economy.⁽⁷¹⁾

The monetary reform included an established universal coinage system, which along with the increasing urbanization, promoted a monetary economy, replacing the barter system to a great extent. Gold and silver coins were minted and used mainly for military, political, and administrative purposes, while copper and other precious metal coins were used for various economic and commercial activities. While gold was rare, and gold coins (*darics*) could be coined only by the Great King, silver and other coins could be minted by *satraps* for payment to soldiers and mercenaries and for commercial and public management purposes. The general term for tax was the old Persian *baji*, the tax collector was *bajikara*. The central treasury was located in Susa, Ecbatana, and Persepolis. Accountants (*hamarakaras*) and treasurers (*ganzabaraz*) were carefully selected and well paid. While the free enterprise system was promoted, state regulations were used to monitor and stabilize the economy.⁽⁷²⁾

Banking activities expanded for the first time in the ancient world, and the number of banking institutions proliferated. The two most famous banking houses Egibi and Marashu and Sons operating in Babylon were but two examples; they were contracted out by the state for tax collection and financial management. Despite the prosperous and stabilized economy, the peasantry throughout the Empire experienced hardship, for they paid the heavy price of

taxation and supply of labor. The urban working class shared that hardship too, but they had the advantage of mobility, whereas the peasantry was mostly confined to the land under the aristocratic nobility, who both suppressed and protected the peasantry. This benevolent behavior of the feudal nobility has been a major structural aspect of the Iranian land tenure and rural-agrarian society well into the middle of the twentieth century.⁽⁷³⁾ Taxes of all kinds were collected with efficiency, and pay for services was a common financial management practice, particularly in urban areas. Public managers rarely had cash flow problems, for the treasury system had a constant flow of revenues coming in. The Persepolis treasury was the largest in the recorded history of the ancient world.⁽⁷⁴⁾

Legal Reforms and Justice Administration

Darius's legal and judicial reforms were probably among the most famous and recognized elements of his administrative reform package. Like the universal coinage and standardization of weights and measures and comparative values of prices in the economy, Darius's Universal Ordinance of Laws and codes were significant measures that were applied equally throughout the Empire. The Universal Law of Darius recognized no status or favoritism and was enforced by the Persian administration and Persian judges who, according to Herodotus and other sources, never failed to serve universal justice.⁽⁷⁵⁾ And as stated in the Bible, "the law of the Medes and Persians does not change."⁽⁷⁶⁾

Darius borrowed from the Babylonian law of Hamurabi, but his universal law was distinctive in several ways: Unlike any previous laws, Darius's laws were both comprehensive and universal; they covered almost every aspect of political, social, economic, legal, military, and administrative systems, and the laws were applied throughout the entire Empire. Whereas the Hamurabi law was confined to the royal court of Babylon, the Universal Law

of Darius was enforced in far extended districts of the realm. The Old Persian terms of *data* and *data-bara* were used for law and judges respectively, and local judges, *dayyan*, were also used in local court trials. Ordeal trials were used with witnesses necessary for delivery of the verdict. Use of trial attorneys was allowed, and judges and court procedures were inspected periodically by the royal representatives from the central administration of justice. Cyrus the Great established, and Darius's reform reinforced, a universal policy of fairness and justice as a foundation of state stability. Darius also ordered the collection and study of Egyptian and Elamite legal codes for consideration in his legal reform. Thus, administration of justice constituted an essential component of Darius's administrative reforms. But injustice and repression were not uncommon from time to time after Darius, particularly during the second century of the Empire.⁽⁷⁷⁾

Local Government Reform

The administrative structure of the local governments in the *satrapies* was modeled after the central administration, with variations reflecting diversity of geographical, ethnic, and cultural regions. Variation in local government administration was also a reflection of the universal policy of tolerance by the Persian administrative state toward the subject peoples. Such flexibility in local administrative leadership and governance served the united state of Persia, but it also presented potential for possible abuse of privilege. But the functions of the local governments did not change, as they all performed similar tasks of the bureaucracy. And the bureaucracy was the unifying institution of power and administration for the central government in Susa and Persepolis.

Darius's reform changed certain conditions in the local government, all aimed at better coordination between the local and central administrations. Direct local-central contacts were allowed for the first time between the two levels of government. This

earlier traditions the Persians so dearly maintained. They never took Alexander's quest seriously, and they never made adequate preparation to meet such an onslaught, nor did they send adequate forces to stop his advances.⁽⁷⁹⁾ Nothing had happened in the last half century of the Empire "to show that Persia was too weak to resist a serious invasion, especially if anything should arouse Iranian national sentiment."⁽⁸⁰⁾

CONCLUSION: IMPLICATIONS FOR MODERN PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION

The Persian tradition of public administration dates back as early as 6000 B.C., when the first experiences in state building and administration began in the Near East. As a city state and one of the earliest sites of human civilization, Susa in Iran began political life around 6000 B.C., leading to the first Iranian tradition of administration on a mass scale. As a contemporary power to Sumer, Babylon, and Assyria, Susa expanded its political life as the capital of the federated Elamite empire for over 2,500 years, then the capital of the mightiest empire on earth, the Persian Achaemenid Empire.

The Iranian experience in state building and public administration, therefore, continued to dominate the entire Near/Middle East, Asia, and major parts of Europe, though Iran also received initial influence from the settled civilization of the Mesopotamia. For well over 2,500 years of rule with a federal system of government, the Elamites left behind many traditions of government, politics, administration, law, and civilization; their legacies included the Elamite language, used as an official language of the Elamite and Persian bureaucracies for over 3,000 years. Elamite contributions to art, religion, politics, and public management were considerable; their public management achieved a remarkable innovation in developing a gigantic underground irrigation system stretching thousands of miles, turning an arid land into a fertile one.